

ETH-06 · CODE OF ETHICS

Raising concerns: complaints, investigations, sanctions

The routes, the protections and their limits, the investigation, and the range of outcomes

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PROJECT CONTROLS INSTITUTE GLOBAL, INC.

AI proposes. The professional disposes.

— Summary

How a concern about the conduct of a PCI candidate or certificant is raised and handled: which of the three routes applies, how to raise a concern inside your own organisation first and when to bring it to the Institute, what a usable report contains, how an investigation runs and what fair process guarantees, the range of outcomes available and their limits, the appeal to the Appeals Panel, and — stated plainly — what protection the Institute can offer a person who raises a concern and what it cannot, because legal protection against retaliation is a matter of local law and varies enormously.

— About this document

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Raising concerns: complaints, investigations, sanctions

In one paragraph. This document sets out how a concern about the conduct of a PCI candidate or certificant is raised and handled: which of three distinct routes applies, when to raise a matter inside your own organisation first and when to bring it to the Institute, what a usable report contains, how an investigation runs and what fair process guarantees the person concerned, the range of outcomes available and their limits, and the appeal that follows an adverse decision. It also states plainly what protection the Institute can offer someone who raises a concern and what it cannot — because protection against retaliation by an employer is a matter of local law, it varies enormously between countries and employment arrangements, and no professional body can confer it.

Who this is for. Anyone considering raising a concern about a PCI candidate or certificant; anyone who is the subject of one; and the employers, sponsors and clients who need to know that the credential means something after it has been awarded.

— 1. Three different things, three different routes

The most common failure in this area is procedural: a person with a genuine matter sends it down the wrong route, and the delay is read as indifference. Three things are routinely conflated.

What it is	Route	Decided by
A concern about a person's conduct — a candidate or certificant is alleged to have breached the Code	Conduct concern (\$3–\$4)	The body designated to determine conduct cases (§6.1)
An appeal against a decision affecting you — eligibility, result, invalidation, certification, or a conduct outcome	Appeal (\$9)	The Appeals Panel, independent of the original decision
A complaint about the Institute — its service, its process, its staff, its systems	Complaint (\$11)	The Institute's complaints route, with impartiality overseen by the Certification & Impartiality Committee

They are deliberately separated so that each decision is made by the right people, and so that no one reviews their own decision.

The Institute's platform records four case types raised by a candidate or certificant through their portal — a **result appeal**, an **invalidation appeal**, a **complaint**, and an **ethics concern** — each moving through the states submitted, under review, and then upheld or dismissed, with supporting evidence attachable to the case and the decision returned through the portal. A concern about someone else's conduct is the ethics route.

[CONFIRM: the published address and web route for raising a conduct concern with PCI by a person who does not hold a portal account]

— 2. Raise it inside your organisation first — ordinarily

2.1 The default

ETH-01 §13.1 expects a concern about conduct to be raised first within the organisation where it arises: line management, project governance, internal audit, or an ethics or compliance route.

This is not deference. It is that the organisation is usually the only body able to fix the thing — correct the report, revise the forecast, re-measure the package, stop the payment. The Institute can act on a person's certification. It cannot correct a project's numbers, direct an employer, recover a loss or award compensation.

2.2 How to raise it internally so that it registers

- **In writing, factually, once.** One paragraph: what you were asked or what you observed, when, by whom, and what you believe is wrong with it. No adjectives.
- **To someone with authority to act**, not to a peer. A concern raised sideways is a conversation.
- **Keep your own copy**, dated, stored somewhere that survives losing access to a system.
- **Say what you want to happen.** "I am asking that the report is not issued until the qualification is reinstated" is actionable; "I am uncomfortable with this" is not.

2.3 When to come to the Institute instead of, or as well as

Ordinarily after the internal route is exhausted or has failed. But go directly where:

- the internal route is compromised — the conduct concerns the people who own it;
- the matter is examination or certification misconduct, which only the Institute can address (impersonation, item disclosure, false eligibility evidence, fraudulent use of a designation);
- there is a risk to safety or a clear public interest that internal escalation is not addressing;
- you no longer work there, and internal escalation is no longer open to you.

[CONFIRM: whether a time limit applies to raising a concern about historic conduct, and any discretion to accept a late report]

— 3. Raising a concern with the Institute

3.1 Who may raise one

Anyone. ETH-01 §13.2 places no restriction: a colleague, a manager, an employer, a client, a competitor, a member of the public, another certificant, or the Institute itself acting on information it holds. You do not need to be affected by the conduct, and you do not need to hold a PCI credential.

3.2 What a usable report contains

A report the Institute can act on says:

1. **Who** — the person concerned, and enough to identify them (name, and where known their credential or the fact they are a candidate).
2. **What** — what they are said to have done, factually, without characterisation.
3. **When and where** — dates, the project or engagement, the role they held.
4. **How you know** — direct observation, a document, something you were told and by whom.
5. **What evidence exists** — and, critically, what evidence you may lawfully and properly provide. See §3.4.
6. **What has already happened** — whether it was raised internally, and with what result.
7. **Your contact details**, and whether you are content to be identified to the person concerned.

Reports that assert a conclusion without the underlying facts are the hardest to progress, because the first step of any investigation is to establish what happened.

3.3 Anonymous reports

[CONFIRM: whether PCI accepts anonymous conduct reports, how they are triaged, and what weight is given to a report that cannot be tested with the reporter]

Two things are true independently of that confirmation. An anonymous report is harder to investigate, because material questions cannot be put back to the source and fairness to the person concerned requires that the allegation be capable of being tested. And an anonymous report of something independently verifiable — a document, a published claim, a designation used by someone who does not hold it — can be perfectly actionable.

3.4 Confidentiality and the evidence you send

Raising a concern does not suspend your own obligations. [ETH-01 §9](#) continues to apply to the material you hold, which means:

- send what is necessary to explain the concern, not everything you have;
- redact third-party personal data you do not need to include;
- do not remove confidential documents from an employer's systems in order to support a report without considering your obligations and, where the matter is significant, taking advice ([ETH-01 §3.3.4](#));
- where you cannot properly provide the underlying document, say what it is and where it is held. The Institute can often obtain it through the person concerned or their employer.

The Institute treats case material as confidential and shares it only as fair process requires — which does include sharing the substance of an allegation with the person it concerns (§5.2).

3.5 Good faith, and the limits of it

[ETH-01 §13.3](#): a person who raises a concern honestly and on reasonable grounds is not in breach because the concern is not upheld. You are not required to be right. You are required to be honest.

Raising a concern you know to be false, or raising one to harass a colleague, damage a competitor or gain advantage in a commercial dispute, is itself a breach of the Code by a certificant and will be treated as one.

— 4. Triage — what happens first

4.1 The report is acknowledged and recorded.

4.2 It is assessed against three questions: is the person within the Institute's jurisdiction (ETH-01 §2); does the conduct described, if established, amount to a breach; and is there enough to investigate.

4.3 One of four things follows: no further action, with reasons given to the reporter; a request for further information; referral to another route (an appeal or a complaint about the Institute); or the opening of an investigation.

4.4 Where the matter is more properly one for an employer, a regulator or a law-enforcement authority, the Institute may say so — and may still investigate the professional-conduct aspect in parallel, since the questions are different.

[CONFIRM: the target time to acknowledge a conduct report, to complete triage, and to conclude an investigation, and how the parties are kept informed of progress]

— 5. Investigation

5.1 Principles

An investigation establishes facts. It is not a prosecution and it does not begin from the assumption that the report is correct. It is conducted by people with no conflict of interest in the matter (ETH-01 §14.3) — which, in a small professional community, is a real constraint that must be managed rather than assumed away.

5.2 What the person concerned is entitled to

- To be told that a concern has been raised, what is alleged, and on what evidence.
- A genuine opportunity to respond, with time proportionate to the complexity of the matter.
- To see the material relied on, subject to the protection of third parties.
- To be accompanied or supported where they are interviewed [CONFIRM: whether a person may be accompanied at an investigation interview, and by whom].
- To have their response recorded and considered.
- A decision with reasons, and a right of appeal (§9).

5.3 What the person concerned must do

ETH-01 §11.4.1 requires cooperation: answering truthfully, and not destroying, altering or withholding relevant records. Non-cooperation is itself a conduct matter, and it is one the Institute takes seriously precisely because the alternative is that the process can be defeated by silence.

Cooperation does not require self-incrimination in another forum. Where a matter is also the subject of legal or regulatory proceedings, say so — timing can usually be managed, and this is a point on which to take your own advice.

5.4 What is gathered

Documents, system records, correspondence, the accounts of people with direct knowledge, and the person's own response. In this discipline the decisive evidence is usually contemporaneous and mundane: a dated measurement sheet, a schedule version, an email sent the same afternoon. This is why [ETH-01 §5.8](#) requires records to be kept — the record protects the professional at least as often as it exposes one.

5.5 Interim measures

[CONFIRM: whether PCI may impose an interim suspension of a credential or of examination eligibility while an investigation is in progress, on whose authority, on what test, and with what right of review]

— 6. Decision

6.1 Who decides

[CONFIRM: which PCI body determines conduct cases at first instance, how its members are appointed, and its relationship to the Certification & Impartiality Committee]

What is settled is the principle: the decision is taken by people independent of the investigation and free of conflicts in the matter, and it is recorded with reasons. The Certification & Impartiality Committee exists in PCI's governance to safeguard exactly that independence.

6.2 The standard applied

[CONFIRM: the standard of proof applied in a conduct determination, and whether it varies with the seriousness of the allegation]

6.3 What is decided

Two questions, separately: whether the conduct occurred, and whether it breached the Code. They are separate because conduct can be established and still fall short of a breach — a professional disagreement about method, a mistake corrected properly, an escalation that was overruled by people entitled to overrule it ([ETH-01 §6.4](#)).

6.4 Reasons

The decision states what was found, what clause was breached, what was taken into account, and what follows. A decision without reasons cannot be appealed intelligibly, which is why reasons are part of fair process rather than a courtesy.

— 7. Outcomes

7.1 The range

ETH-01 §14.4 sets the range as proportionate, running from guidance and a recorded warning, through conditions on continued certification, to suspension and — in serious cases — withdrawal of certification. Where the conduct concerns an examination, an outcome may also include invalidation of a result and loss of the right to resit.

7.2 No tariff is stated, and none should be inferred

[CONFIRM: the published sanction range and any tariff mapping breach categories to outcomes, including the minimum period before a person whose certification has been withdrawn may reapply, and any conditions on reapplication]

The Institute would rather publish nothing than publish a schedule of sanctions it has not adopted. Where a document in this framework could have invented a number, it does not.

7.3 What is weighed

ETH-01 §14.2 lists the factors: whether the conduct was deliberate, reckless or careless; its materiality and who was exposed to it; concealment; repetition; the person's seniority and the reliance placed on them; self-reporting and correction; cooperation; the pressure the person was under, which may mitigate but does not excuse; and any previous finding.

Two of those deserve emphasis because they change outcomes most often. **Concealment** consistently weighs heavier than the original conduct — a corrected error is a professional act, a concealed one is a second breach. And **self-reporting** is genuinely mitigating: a person who brings their own error forward is demonstrating the thing the Code exists to protect.

7.4 Publication

[CONFIRM: whether conduct outcomes are published, in what form, with or without identification of the person, and for how long]

Whatever is decided, the register of who currently holds a valid credential is the Institute's answer to the question an employer actually asks, and verification of a credential is available independently of any conduct history.

7.5 What the Institute cannot do

Stated plainly, because expectations otherwise attach to the wrong body. The Institute cannot: fine an individual or an organisation; award compensation to anyone; require an employer to act, reinstate, or change a report; overturn a commercial decision; correct a project's published numbers; or prevent someone practising in project controls. Its jurisdiction runs to a person's standing with the Institute — their candidature and their certification — and no further.

That is a narrow power. It is also, for a credential that employers rely on, the relevant one.

— 8. Effect on results and credentials

8.1 Where a conduct finding concerns an examination, a result may be invalidated. The consequences for resitting, for fees already paid and for any authorisation are handled under the examination rules for the sitting concerned.

8.2 Where certification is suspended or withdrawn, the person must stop using the designation immediately (ETH-01 §11.5.1), including on professional profiles, signatures, tender documents and company materials. Continued use after withdrawal is a separate and serious breach, and it is the one most likely to be noticed by a third party.

8.3 A credential that has expired for non-renewal is not a sanction and is not recorded as one. Membership grades and certification are separate ladders (ETH-01 §11.5.3); the effect of a conduct outcome on membership standing is governed by the Institute's membership arrangements rather than by this document.

— 9. Appeals

9.1 The right

An adverse decision carries a right of appeal, heard by people independent of the original decision — the **Appeals Panel**. This applies to conduct decisions and to the other decisions that affect a person directly: eligibility, results, invalidation and certification.

9.2 Independence

[CONFIRM: how Appeals Panel members are appointed, how independence from the original decision-maker is assured, and whether an appellant may object to a panel member]

The principle is stated in the Institute's published material and is not in doubt: an appeal is reviewed independently of the people who made the original decision, and raising one never prejudices a person's standing with the Institute.

9.3 Grounds, time limits and fees

[CONFIRM: the time limit for lodging an appeal, the grounds on which an appeal may be brought, whether new evidence may be introduced, and any fee and its refund on a successful appeal]

No timescale, ground or fee is stated in this document, because none may be invented. Where a candidate needs those facts today, they are in the examination rules and appeals policy published for their sitting, and the platform records the appeal from submission through to decision.

9.4 What an appeal is not

An appeal is not a rehearing of the same argument to a different audience, and it is not a route to challenge a professional judgement simply because the outcome is unwelcome. It examines whether the decision was properly made on the evidence, by the right people, following the process — and, where provided for, whether new material changes the position.

— 10. Protection from detriment — what is ours to give, and what is not

This section is the one most likely to be relied on, so it is written without ambiguity.

10.1 What the Institute undertakes

ETH-01 §13.4.1: the Institute will not treat a person adversely **in their standing with the Institute** because they raised a concern in good faith. Raising a concern is not a mark against a candidate, does not affect an application, an examination, a result or a renewal, and is not disclosed to an employer as a matter of course.

If a person believes they have been treated adversely by the Institute for raising a concern, that is itself a complaint about the Institute (§11), and it goes to a different route from the concern that prompted it.

10.2 What the Institute cannot do — and this matters more

The Institute **cannot** protect a person from their employer's response. It cannot prevent a dismissal, a demotion, the withdrawal of work, exclusion from a project, or the informal disadvantage that is far more common than any of those and far harder to evidence. It cannot compel an employer to do anything, cannot appear for a person in any proceedings, and cannot confer any legal protection whatsoever.

10.3 The legal position varies, and no professional body can tell you what it is

Legal protection for a person who reports wrongdoing differs profoundly between jurisdictions, and within a jurisdiction it differs between sectors, between employees and contractors, and over time. In some places statutory protection exists but is conditional — on the subject matter of the disclosure, on the recipient, on the order in which internal and external routes were used, on the person's belief being reasonable, and on procedural steps taken at the right time. In others it is narrow, hard to enforce, or absent. Confidentiality obligations, contractual terms and data laws may also bear on what a person may lawfully disclose and to whom.

Take advice from a qualified adviser in your own jurisdiction before making a disclosure outside your organisation, before resigning over an ethical matter, and before removing any document from an employer's systems. **ETH-01 §3.3.4.** This is not a formality: in several legal systems the protection available depends on steps taken before the disclosure, which cannot be repaired afterwards.

The Institute does not give legal advice, does not underwrite the consequences of a disclosure, and does not want anyone to read encouragement in this document as an assurance of safety it has no power to provide.

10.4 What is nonetheless worth knowing

Two practical points, offered as advice and not as law. First, the record is what survives: dated, factual notes made at the time, held somewhere you will still have access to if you lose your systems, are the difference between a documented escalation and a recollection. Second, escalating inside the organisation first — where it is safe and sensible to do so — is not only what **ETH-01 §13.1** expects; it is also, in many legal frameworks, the step that makes later protection available at all.

— 11. Complaints about the Institute

A complaint about the Institute's service, process, systems, communications or staff is a different matter from a conduct concern about a person, and goes down its own route. The platform records complaints alongside appeals, with the same states and the same portal-based response.

The Certification & Impartiality Committee's function in PCI's governance is to safeguard the impartiality of certification decisions — which includes the handling of complaints that bear on whether decisions were taken fairly and free of commercial or personal influence.

Complaints about impartiality specifically — that a certification decision was influenced by a commercial relationship, a training relationship, or a personal connection — should say so expressly, because they are routed differently from a service complaint.

— 12. Records and privacy of case material

12.1 Case material contains personal data about the reporter, the person concerned and third parties, and is handled accordingly under the applicable data-protection framework, which varies by jurisdiction (ETH-01 §9.4).

12.2 Material is shared only as fair process requires. The person concerned will ordinarily learn the substance of the allegation; whether they learn the reporter's identity depends on the circumstances and on what the reporter has agreed (§3.2, point 7).

12.3 **[CONFIRM: the retention period for conduct case records, and whether an unsubstantiated allegation is retained and for how long]**

— 13. If a concern is raised about you

Six things, in order, and they are the same six whether the concern is well-founded or not.

1. **Read what is alleged, precisely.** Most responses answer a broader accusation than the one actually made, and in doing so introduce material nobody had asked about.
 2. **Assemble the contemporaneous record** — the schedule versions, the measurement sheets, the email you sent that afternoon. Do not create anything new and date it as if it were old; that converts a defensible position into a certain finding.
 3. **Do not contact the reporter** to discuss it, and do not attempt to establish who they are.
 4. **Answer honestly, including where you were wrong.** Self-correction is weighed in your favour (§7.3). Concealment is weighed heavily against you, and it is usually the concealment that determines the outcome.
 5. **Take your own advice** where the matter also has legal or employment consequences — the Institute's process and your employer's process are separate, and they can run at different speeds.
 6. **Cooperate.** ETH-01 §11.4.1 requires it, and non-cooperation is a breach in its own right that costs more than almost any answer you could give.
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— 14. Checklist — before you raise a concern

- [] Which of the three routes is this: conduct, appeal, or complaint about the Institute? (§1)
- [] Have I raised it internally, and what happened — or is there a good reason not to? (§2.3)
- [] Can I state what happened in factual sentences, with dates, without characterisation? (§3.2)
- [] What evidence exists, and what may I properly provide? (§3.4)
- [] Am I raising this honestly and on reasonable grounds? (§3.5)
- [] Am I content to be identified to the person concerned, and if not, why not? (§3.2)
- [] Do I understand what the Institute can and cannot do about it? (§7.5, §10.2)
- [] Have I taken local advice, if this involves disclosing anything outside my organisation? (§10.3)
- [] Have I kept my own dated copy of everything I have sent? (§10.4)

A credential is only worth what happens after it is awarded. A body that publishes a code and no route for enforcing it is publishing an aspiration — and the people most disadvantaged by that are the professionals who followed the code when it cost them something.

— Related

- [ETH-01 – The PCI code of ethics and professional conduct](#) — §13 and §14 are the clauses this document operates
- [ETH-03 – Reporting numbers under pressure: a casebook](#) — what escalation looks like before it becomes a case
- [ETH-04 – Conflicts of interest in project controls](#) — the conflicts that must be managed inside the process as well as outside it
- [CER-07 – Results, scoring, appeals and complaints](#) — the candidate-facing view of the appeal and complaint routes
- [EXB-07 – Examination security and integrity](#) — how examination misconduct is detected and what follows

— Sources and standards

- [ETH-01 – The PCI code of ethics and professional conduct](#) (this framework) — §11.4, §13 and §14.
 - PCI Candidate Handbook, [docs/downloads/candidate-handbook.md](#), repository copy read August 2026 — the separation of appeals from complaints, the fair-process guarantees, and the statement that raising an appeal never prejudices a candidate's standing.
 - PCI platform casework module, [backend/Endpoints/Casework.cs](#), read August 2026 — the four recorded case types (result appeal, invalidation appeal, complaint, ethics concern), the case states (submitted, under review, upheld, dismissed), and the portal-based response.
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No external legal source is cited and none should be inferred. The statements in §10.3 about variation in whistleblowing and employment protection are general observations; the only reliable source for any individual's position is a qualified adviser in their own jurisdiction.

— Status and version

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